Go / Pivot / Kill — Decision Framework

The hardest skill in entrepreneurship is knowing when to stop.

When to Use This

Use this framework at the end of each validation cycle (every 2-3 weeks) or whenever your team is stuck debating whether to continue, change direction, or kill the idea.

This is the Google X “Astro Teller” method: **try to kill your idea as fast as possible.** The ideas that survive the killing are the ones worth building.

The Decision Matrix

Answer each question honestly. Score each as Yes (✓) or No (✗).

PROBLEM SIGNALS

#	Question	✓/✗
1	Have 5+ non-friends described this problem unprompted?	
2	Are people currently spending time OR money on workarounds?	
3	Does the problem occur at least weekly for your target user?	

SOLUTION SIGNALS

#	Question	✓/✗
4	Have users engaged with your prototype/landing page without prompting?	
5	Can you explain why your approach is 10x better (not 10% better)?	
6	Is there a reason this solution is possible NOW that wasn't possible 2 years ago?	

TRACTION SIGNALS

#	Question	✓/✗
7	Has anyone given you money, a pre-order, or a signed LOI?	
8	Are users coming back without you pushing them?	
9	Is at least one metric growing week-over-week?	

Reading the Score

7-9 ✓ → GO. You have real signal. Double down. Stop exploring, start executing. Your biggest risk is now speed — someone else sees this too.

4-6 ✓ → PIVOT. Something is working, but not everything. Identify WHICH questions are ✗ and change your approach to those specifically: - Problem ✗ → You're solving the wrong problem. Go back to discovery. - Solution ✗ → Right problem, wrong approach. Rethink your 10x insight. - Traction ✗ → Right product, wrong channel or audience. Change WHO you're selling to or HOW.

0-3 ✓ → KILL. This is not working. Killing an idea is not failure — it's the fastest path to finding one that works. The best founders kill fast.

The Pivot Menu

If your score says PIVOT, pick one:

Pivot Type	What Changes	What Stays	Example
Customer Pivot	Who you sell to	The product	Slack: gaming → enterprise
Problem Pivot	Which problem you solve	The customer	Instagram: location check-in → photo sharing
Solution Pivot	How you solve it	The problem	YouTube: video dating → video sharing
Channel Pivot	How you reach users	Everything else	—
Revenue Pivot	How you make money	The product + user	—

Rule: Only pivot ONE thing at a time. If you change everything, you're not pivoting — you're starting over.

The Kill Ritual

When you kill an idea, write down:

1. **What we learned** (not "it didn't work" — what SPECIFICALLY didn't work)
2. **What surprised us** (the most interesting unexpected finding)
3. **What we'd tell someone starting this idea** (in 3 sentences)

This turns a "failure" into an asset. The best next idea often comes from insight #2.

Pre-Mortem: Do This BEFORE You Start

Before running your next experiment, write:

> *"It's 3 weeks from now. This experiment failed completely. What went wrong?"*

List the top 3 reasons. Then design your experiment to test for those reasons FIRST. This is Astro Teller’s core method at X (Google): seek the fatal flaw before investing in the vision.